

The environmental argument against AI is hypocritical

Posted by u/Witty-Designer7316 • • 0 points • 23 comments

SOURCES FOR ENERGY COMPARISONS IN THE POSTER

AI ENERGY USE (BASELINE)

Elsworth et al. (2024), arXiv

“Median energy use per AI text prompt is approximately 0.24 Wh, comparable to only a few seconds of television viewing.”

<https://arxiv.org/abs/2508.15734>

VIDEO STREAMING VS AI

National Centre for AI (UK), Jisc

“Video streaming services such as Netflix and YouTube consume substantially more energy per hour of use than generative AI services.”

[<https://nationalcentreforai.jiscinvolve.org/wp/2025/05/02/artificial-intelligence-and-the-environment-putting-the-numbers-into-perspective/>]

(<https://nationalcentreforai.jiscinvolve.org/wp/2025/05/02/artificial-intelligence-and-the-environment-putting-the-numbers-into-perspective/>)

NETFLIX / YOUTUBE / ZOOM COMPARISONS

Forbes, John Koetsier

“Streaming video and video conferencing services like Netflix, YouTube, and Zoom use significantly more energy per hour than typical AI interactions.”

[<https://www.forbes.com/sites/johnkoetsier/2025/12/03/new-data-ai-is-almost-green-compared-to-netflix-zoom-youtube/>]

(<https://www.forbes.com/sites/johnkoetsier/2025/12/03/new-data-ai-is-almost-green-compared-to-netflix-zoom-youtube/>)

DATA CENTER CONTEXT (AI IS A FRACTION OF TOTAL LOAD)

Pew Research Center

“AI workloads are only one portion of total data center electricity demand, which is dominated by video streaming, cloud services, and everyday online activity.”

<https://www.pewresearch.org/short-reads/2025/10/24/what-we-know-about-energy-use-at-us-data-centers-amid-the-ai-boom/>

GAMING AND HIGH-INTENSITY ONLINE SERVICES

Mucky Paws Analysis (compiled from industry energy data)

“Cloud gaming and high-performance PC gaming can consume orders of magnitude more electricity per hour than AI text-based services.”

[<https://muckypaws.com/2025/04/21/is-ai-really-the-energy-villain/>]
(<https://muckypaws.com/2025/04/21/is-ai-really-the-energy-villain/>)

GENERAL CARBON / ENERGY CONTEXT

Sustainability by Numbers

“Per-query emissions from large language models are small compared to common digital activities such as streaming video or gaming.”

[<https://www.sustainabilitybynumbers.com/p/carbon-footprint-chatgpt>]
(<https://www.sustainabilitybynumbers.com/p/carbon-footprint-chatgpt>)

((((I would like to credit PureAnna for this information and first image))))

Comments

u/[deleted] • -1 points • 2026-03-05 22:00 UTC

[removed]

u/A_Very_Horny_Zed • 1 points • 2026-03-07 02:41 UTC

This has been removed for violating Reddit's Content Policy. Do not spam.

u/Nervlines • 0 points • 2026-03-03 14:19 UTC

Depends on what the AI is being used for. We talking a still picture with few details or a 10 min 60 frame seedance style movie.

If it's the first, I can definitely agree with your statement, the latter feels more far fetched.

u/ReadingClock123 • 1 points • 2026-03-03 11:56 UTC

Excuse me?

Sitting on your ass and watching YT takes energy?

You suck out my energy to live 🤔

u/GenesisVariex • 1 points • 2026-03-02 21:21 UTC

Actual facts!! Ty for posting I love your art!! :D

u/[deleted] • 1 points • 2026-03-02 08:40 UTC

[deleted]

u/Think_Locksmith2648 • 1 points • 2026-03-01 23:24 UTC

Thank you, I'm going to use each of these at the same time on several devices

u/Tyrthemis • 2 points • 2026-03-01 16:27 UTC

Um I appreciate the sentiment, but what is "using AI"? a chat gpt question is wildly different than an AI video.

"The worst thing you can do for a cause is argue it poorly"

u/The_Wise_Wolf_Itself • 1 points • 2026-03-01 14:51 UTC

"You still used it"

-Anti ai

I deadass saw people saying this when people were defending an artist that tried AI for the first time

"Bro she used Ai only once it's not as if she was going to use it forever now"

"She still used it"

u/RightLiterature2958 • 1 points • 2026-03-01 11:40 UTC

Welp, if that's the case, I can say bye bye to my 200 More Students Mod I have. Shame to waste it.

[https://preview.redd.it/je7zg73s7fmg1.png?](https://preview.redd.it/je7zg73s7fmg1.png?width=663&format=png&auto=webp&s=0595b6af52ee7f3c72c363a4c417d38548ba7a81)

[width=663&format=png&auto=webp&s=0595b6af52ee7f3c72c363a4c417d38548ba7a81](https://preview.redd.it/je7zg73s7fmg1.png?width=663&format=png&auto=webp&s=0595b6af52ee7f3c72c363a4c417d38548ba7a81)

u/Maleficent_Sir_7562 • 1 points • 2026-03-01 09:34 UTC

I still remember when I tried to show sources to a guy about how ai doesn't use much energy or water.

Then he said those sources (latest ones) were somehow wrong and then gave me a bunch of sources that ai does use a lot of water.

And then he kept on getting contradicted by his own sources, and most of the sources are extremely old, seeing the water usage of gpt 3 and 4, where ai was still extremely un optimized.

Then when I pointed that out, bro just said "I see a lot of attempts to discredit the data, but it's not working", said nothing else, and left.

u/billjames1685 • 1 points • 2026-03-02 03:29 UTC

Those sources were wrong, FYI (the water usage of gpt 3 and 4). Those models didn't use much water either. There was a massive misconception in one source that ended up with the whole "10 ChatGPT queries = bottle of water" myth, and that statistic was subsequently used for many future "studies".

u/Groundbreaking-Sir82 • 1 points • 2026-03-01 09:08 UTC

even in such situation i bet all my life savings antis will just say "but you couldve chosen not to add to it even more duh" despite that working against them as well

u/Raudys • 0 points • 2026-03-01 02:45 UTC

It's more and more ridiculous the more you look into it.

u/Maximum-Country-149 • 1 points • 2026-03-01 00:55 UTC

Not the first time "it's bad for the environment" has been used as motivated reasoning, and it won't be the last.

u/SatisfactionEast9815 • 1 points • 2026-03-01 05:57 UTC

When has that been used before?

u/Steamed_Memes24 • 1 points • 2026-03-01 10:52 UTC

Vegans constantly use this as the first wave of attack lol.

u/SatisfactionEast9815 • 1 points • 2026-03-03 04:10 UTC

Is veganism actually better for the environment?

u/Steamed_Memes24 • 0 points • 2026-03-03 08:34 UTC

Yes, though im no vegan, if everyone were to stop eating meat and switch to alternate rich protein sources global warming would be curbed quite heavily.

u/SatisfactionEast9815 • 1 points • 2026-03-04 01:59 UTC

Wow, got it.

u/Enough_Lawfulness247 • -2 points • 2026-03-01 00:30 UTC